



AI use in American newspapers is widespread, uneven, and rarely disclosed

Jenna Russell  Marzena Karpinska  Destiny Akinode 

Katherine Thai  Bradley Emi  Max Spero  Mohit Iyyer 

 University of Maryland, College Park  Microsoft  UMass Amherst  Pangram Labs

{jennarus,miyyer}@umd.edu, mkarpinska@microsoft.com

[ainewsaudit.github.io](https://github.com/ainewsaudit)

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HUMANE Lab 석사과정 고경빈

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Background

- AI is rapidly transforming journalism
- LLMs often hallucinate and inherit social bias, resulting in reduced factuality
- Transparency is essential to maintain trust
- But, the extent of AI use in newspaper articles remains unclear

Dataset

- recent_news(2025.6.15 ~ 2025.09.15)
 - 186,507 articles published online by 1,528 unique newspapers
- opinions(2022.08 ~ 2025.09)
 - 44,803 opinion articles published by the New York Times, Washington Post, and Wall Street Journal
- ai_reporters
 - Identify 10 veteran reporters who published articles both before and after the release of ChatGPT and at least three of their articles were identified as MIXED or AI-GENERATED
 - 20,132 articles from 14 newspapers

Annotation

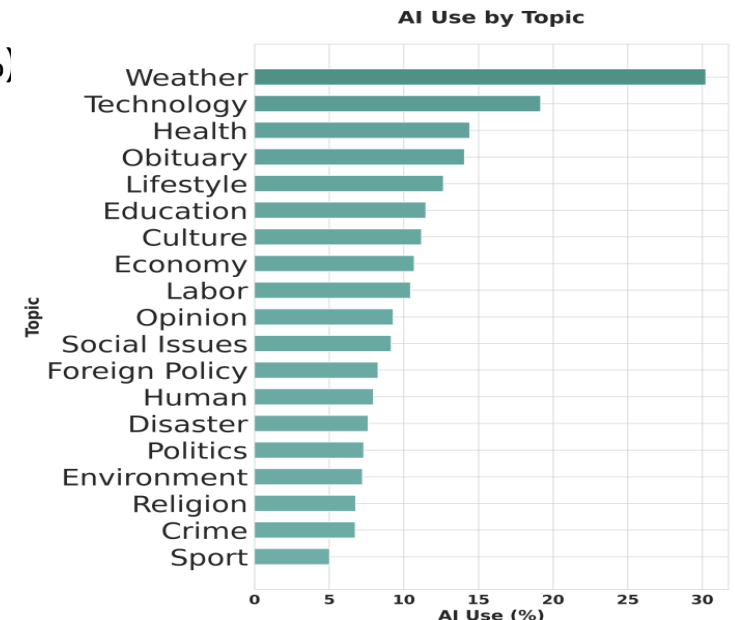
- Detecting **AI use** with Pangram API
 - Likelihood (0-100%)
 - Text Label: HUMAN-WRITTEN, MIXED, AI-GENERATED
- **Topic** classification by using Qwen3-8B
- Linking to **circulation** and **ownership** by using US News Deserts Database

```
"Pangram_AI_Result": {  
  "text": "수도권 집값이 급등하는 가운데 시중 유동성이 또다시 증가해 부동산 시장 과열 우려가 커지고 있다.\n한국은행이 13일 발표한 '7월  
  "version": "3.0",  
  "headline": "Fully AI Generated",  
  "prediction": "We are confident that this document is fully AI-generated",  
  "prediction_short": "AI",  
  "fraction_ai": 1.0,  
  "fraction_ai_assisted": 0.0,  
  "fraction_human": 0.0,  
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  "num_ai_assisted_segments": 0,  
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  {  
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    "confidence": "Low",  
    "start_index": 0,  
    "end_index": 791,  
    "word_count": 180,  
    "token_length": 468  
  },
```

How often is AI used in American newspapers?

- 9.1% of the recent_news are labeled as either AI-GENERATED (5.2%) or MIXED (3.9%)
- AI use varies by newspaper scale and region
 - Smaller outlets(circulation < 100K) rely on AI more than national newspapers(circulation >100K)
 - AI use varies by region, being most prevalent in mid-Atlantic and Southern states, while remaining low in the Northeast
- AI use varies with topic
 - Observe high AI use in 'Weather' (27.7%), 'Technology' (16.1%) and 'Health' (11.7%)
 - Content on more sensitive issues(crime, religion, etc.,) exhibit lower rates



How often is AI used in American newspapers?

- AI use varies with **ownership**
 - Some groups(e.g., Boone News Media) prioritize cost savings while others avoid it due to reputational risks
- AI use is higher in **languages** other than English
 - AI use is far more common in non-English news articles (31.0%) than in English ones (8.0%)
- AI use varies by topic across ownership groups

AI Use by Top 20 Ownership Groups, Split by Topic

Owner	Obituary	Technology	Lifestyle	Health	Weather	Education	Foreign Policy	Labor	Opinion	Culture	Economy	Human	Disaster	Environment	Politics	Religion	Crime	Social Issues	Sport	Overall
Boone Newspapers	16.9	66.7	47.1	34.0		19.1		27.3	7.1	27.2	28.1	14.3	8.8	4.2	11.5	14.3	9.2	20.0	9.3	18.3
Advance Publications	20.0	26.7	14.0	16.9	74.4	15.0		30.8		10.6	10.4	9.2	27.9	14.7	2.9		4.5	0.0	5.7	13.4
Morris Multimedia	5.5		17.4	23.1		13.6		4.3		11.8	15.0	8.3	22.2	15.2	14.3	0.0	12.2	0.0	3.4	11.8
AIM Media		40.0	29.4	19.6		21.6		10.0	16.7	15.8	10.0	4.2	6.7	9.5	13.5	33.3	10.0	3.0	1.1	11.8
Swift Newspapers	25.9	5.6	17.1	16.2	11.1	18.2		17.4	23.5	12.9	10.6	10.6	3.6	10.3	8.0		1.6	3.3	3.8	10.6
CNHI	15.4	0.0	5.0	12.7	0.0	12.9		0.0	0.0	8.9	6.4	8.9	3.8	5.4	5.9	10.5	4.4	3.4	4.1	6.9
Gannett/Gatehouse		13.6	11.9	10.4	3.7	8.1	16.7	8.9	0.0	7.7	4.2	3.8	1.5	15.4	3.7	5.3	4.0	15.0	0.9	6.3
Rust Communications	15.7	11.1	20.0	7.0		12.8	5.6	7.1		7.7	1.1	11.3	10.3	0.0	4.2	3.4	4.0	0.0	4.1	6.2
Pamplin Media Group	22.4		5.0	0.0		4.2		8.3	33.3	5.8	9.9	9.4	2.0	6.2	2.8		6.3	5.9	0.0	5.7
Adams Publishing Group	27.4	25.8	5.0	10.8	0.0	9.1	0.0	2.1	0.0	5.0	7.2	3.8	1.8	3.4	4.9	0.0	2.1	6.3	2.1	5.0
Paxton Media Group	12.3	9.1	3.7	9.8		6.5	0.0	5.9	0.0	6.0	5.8	2.0	15.5	4.2	4.2	0.0	2.5	2.5	0.5	4.8
Ogden Newspapers	9.1	0.0	8.8	3.4	0.0	2.0		2.6		3.5	2.8	12.5	4.1	1.3	2.9	0.0	1.0	0.0	6.7	3.5
News + Media Capital Group LLC		0.0	3.3	2.9		8.0		8.0	7.7	0.8	7.2	7.1	0.0	2.6	4.4		0.5	0.0	2.4	3.2
Tribune/Digital First	13.1	9.7	2.7	3.8	2.0	5.9	24.4	0.6	11.1	2.8	1.4	1.7	0.7	3.1	2.9	0.0	2.0	2.6	2.9	2.9
East Oregonian Publishing Company		0.0	0.0	0.0		0.0		5.6	0.0	2.6	3.7	0.0	1.3	1.0	5.4	0.0	3.0	0.0	0.0	2.4
Lee/Bh Media	2.9	13.6	4.1	7.3		6.2	20.0	3.6	0.0	2.8	1.6	2.6	2.8	2.4	1.3	0.0	0.4	0.0	0.5	2.4
Forum Communications		0.0	0.0	4.1	0.0	3.1	0.0	0.0		3.6	2.7	4.2	2.6	2.2	4.3	0.0	2.0	3.2	0.0	2.3
Soon-Shiong, Patrick		9.1	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0		3.0		0.7	1.3	4.8	0.0	0.0	2.6		1.6	3.1	1.0	1.5
Nash Holdings (Jeff Bezos)	0.0	2.2	2.0	2.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	2.8	0.0	0.8	0.9	2.2	0.0	1.2	1.0	0.0	0.7	2.1	0.2	1.0
News Corp		1.9	0.0	0.0		3.7	1.7	2.7	0.0	0.4	0.6	2.8	0.0	0.0	1.1	0.0	0.8	0.0	0.0	0.7

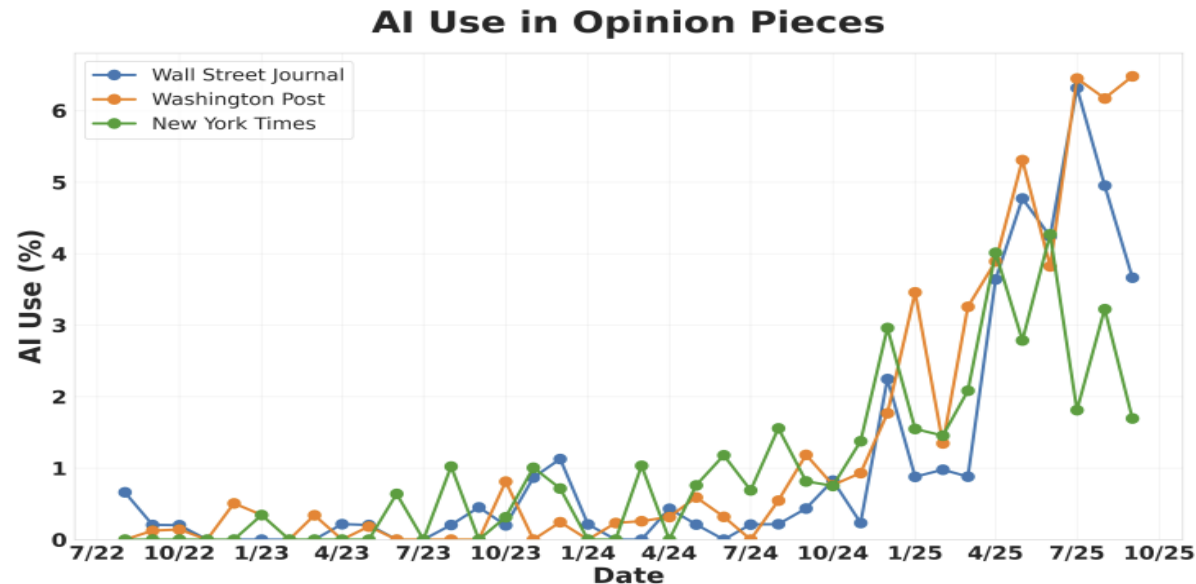
Characterizing AI use in American newspapers

- Many articles have **mixed** authorship
 - 'Mixed' makes up 42.7% of all detected AI content
 - Most journalists who use AI (54.8%) primarily publish mixed articles
- AI use is largely **undisclosed**
 - In a sample of 100 AI-flagged articles, 95% of authors and 91% of publishers didn't disclose AI use
 - Even newspapers with explicit AI bans(e.g., New York Post) published AI-generated content in violation of their policies
- Many AI-generated articles contain **authentic quotes**
 - 76.1% of articles contained at least one human-written quote

Notable individual cases of AI use

- Argonaut: a fully AI-generated newspaper featuring fake AI reporter personas
- Reporters republishing old work rewritten by AI
- The advice column Dear Annie using AI for responses

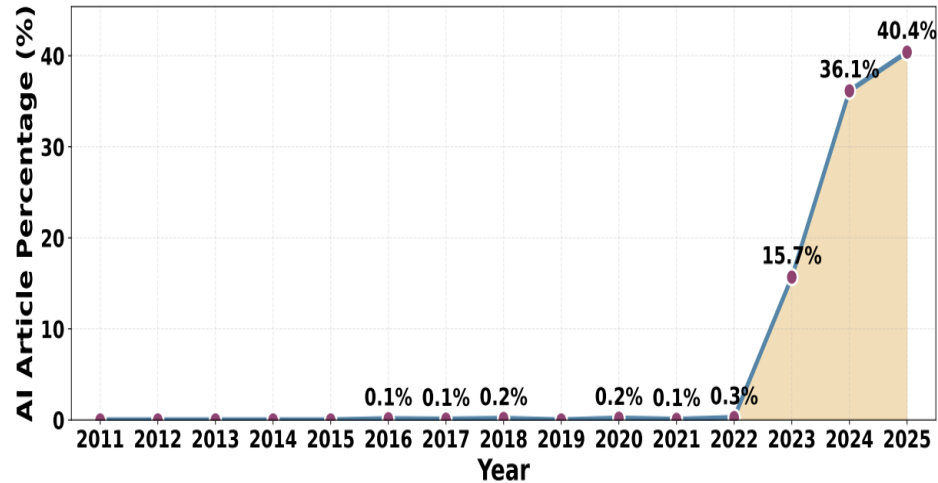
Opinions



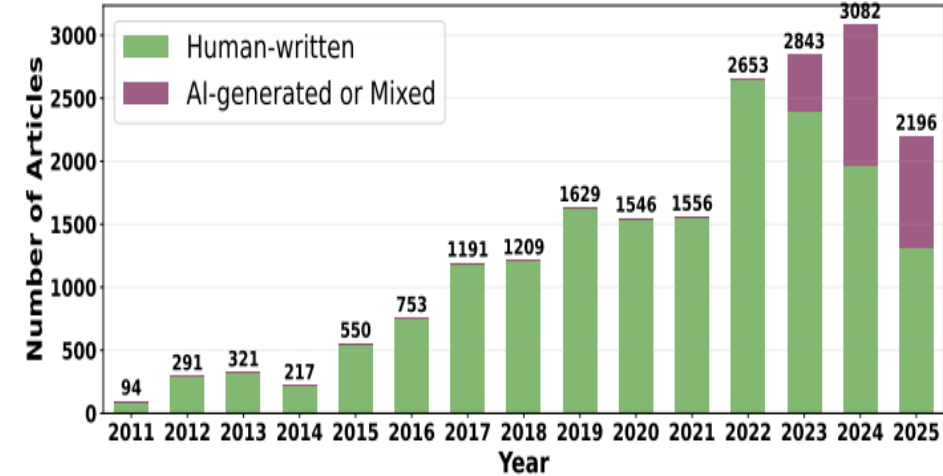
- AI use in opinions at reputable newspapers has increased by 25x over the past 3 years
- Opinions use AI 6.4x more frequently than regular news
- Guest contributors are much more likely to use AI in opinion pieces than full-time reporters
- AI use in opinions is expanding from science to all other topics

Tracking reporter adoption of AI

AI use over time (%)



Article count by year



- AI use by these reporters rises from 0% pre-ChatGPT to 40% in 2025
- While AI use varies across this cohort of reporters, none discloses their AI use
- AI traces are visible in the articles
 - AI-generated text tends to overuse specific punctuation(e.g., em dash(-))
 - Human writing is characterized by concrete details like specific names and locations

Conclusion

- First large-scale audit of AI use across 250k articles from three complementary corpora of U.S. newspaper articles
 - AI use is widespread (9%) but uneven, with a notable surge in opinion pieces at major national papers
- Suggest some disclosure policies that newspapers could consider adopting to improve public trust
 - Implementing clear guidelines defining acceptable AI use and mandatory disclosure requirements
 - Specifically for opinion, editors must require guest authors to disclose AI use and verify their work

My Opinion

- This study is significant because it is the first to analyze AI use in news using real data
- Nowadays, news uses AI for both text and images. However, this study is limited because it only analyzed text
- Since the study only used the Pangram API, it is impossible to know exactly how the AI was used